

Chapter 17-1

The rich fragrance continuously permeated the air.

With every breath, her nostrils were filled with this scent.

Liang Shi's lower abdomen was taut, and her arm brushed against Xu Qingzhu's skin.

It carried a slight coolness.

But this coolness couldn't dissolve the burning heat in one's body at all.

Liang Shi turned her face away slightly and also shifted her body toward the other side of the bed.

The hottest spot was her shoulder.

It seemed as if hot tears had fallen onto it, soaking through her T-shirt.

That patch of skin on her shoulder was burning intensely.

She must have encountered something troubling, Liang Shi thought.

But Liang Shi didn't ask.

She didn't know if Xu Qingzhu, like herself, preferred not to have people speak in such an atmosphere.

She only needed a shoulder to lean on, to absorb some energy.

Even just a little bit would do.

If Xu Qingzhu wanted to talk, she would naturally speak.

If she didn't want to, Liang Shi would simply be her reliable support.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu didn't stay long.

She leaned for a while, then withdrew. In the darkness, Liang Shi could vaguely make out her silhouette.

She sat up, supporting herself on the bed with both arms, her back facing Liang Shi, her face turned toward the window. In that instant, Liang Shi felt she looked very lonely.

It was the same kind of loneliness as her own.

But it was only for a moment. Xu Qingzhu bent down to put on her shoes, stood up and picked up her phone. Her voice had already returned to its cool tone, though if you listened carefully, you could still tell she had been crying.

"I'll leave first," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi also sat up. "Don't you plan to say anything?"

Xu Qingzhu's footsteps paused. "What would you like to hear?"

"Didn't you say earlier that you wanted to chat?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I don't want to anymore."

Liang Shi: "....."

She was quite capricious indeed.

But it was rather interesting.

Liang Shi had thought Xu Qingzhu would be the type who was introverted, cool, gentle, and reserved, but she hadn't expected that getting to know her would be so surprising.

She wasn't rigidly intelligent, nor was it a deliberately crafted persona.

She just appeared quiet, gentle, and aloof on the surface, but actually had a heart that was both fiery and resilient.

Very much like... a wolf in sheep's clothing¹.

Also very much like... a master of deception².

Liang Shi responded indifferently: "Oh."

She didn't force it either, and lay back down on the bed. Xu Qingzhu walked to the door and stopped again, calling out in a low voice: "Liang Shi."

"Mm?" Liang Shi responded with a nasal sound.

"You owe me a favor, right?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"Tonight," Xu Qingzhu reminded her. "Zhou Yi'an has always been hiding her gender from the public."

"Then how did you know?" Liang Shi asked.

"I have a friend who treated her."

"Is it Zhao Xuning?"

Xu Qingzhu paused. "That has nothing to do with you."

"Then why did you tell me?" Liang Shi stood up, approaching step by step. "Simply to help me?"

"What do you think?"

"I think it's not." Liang Shi moved closer to her, able to smell the light fragrance from her hair. "You've always wanted to divorce me. If I got together with Zhou Yi'an, then you would get your wish, but you didn't do that. Given how much you dislike me, I wouldn't simply believe that you told me this out of concern for me, so... what's your purpose? Or rather, what else do you want to get from me?"

She was very close, almost pressed against Xu Qingzhu as she said these words.

Her lips were just a tiny bit away from Xu Qingzhu's ear.

Xu Qingzhu didn't move at all.

Hearing this, she laughed softly, then restrained her smile. "Regardless of the purpose, the fact that I helped you is true, right? So you owe me a favor."

"Then what do you want me to do?" Liang Shi asked. "Does the Xu family company still need financing? You heard my phone call just now, didn't you? Right now the Liang family can barely protect itself and needs to sell off their daughter to obtain a piece of land. I probably can't help you."

"I haven't thought of it yet," Xu Qingzhu said. "When I think of something, I'll have you repay it. No need to rush."

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi stepped back half a step. "You're completely different from before now."

She stated this fact in a calm tone.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly turned around, a smile playing at the corner of her mouth. "Then isn't there a possibility that you've never truly understood me?"

Liang Shi was momentarily speechless.

"You should rest," Xu Qingzhu said and left the hospital room.

Liang Shi stood in place, only coming back to her senses when she heard the door close.

Footnotes:

¹ Wolf in sheep's clothing (白切黑): A Chinese internet term describing someone who appears innocent and harmless on the surface but is actually cunning or dark-hearted underneath.

² Master of deception (扮豬吃老虎): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "pretending to be a pig to eat the tiger," referring to someone who deliberately appears weak or foolish to deceive others and gain an advantage.